the high command installed him as Karnataka Congress president, with public backing from the Gandhis.

DKS is also someone who does not take no for an answer. The trait was on display in December 2024, when, paying tribute to his late mentor and former CM S.M. Krishna in the assembly, DKS recalled how he became a minister in the latter's government (1999-2004). "I had sat with Krishna to make the list of ministers and their portfolios. But in the final list that went to the governor, my name was missing," he told the House. Heeding his astrologer's advice to "take by force" what was owed to him, he woke Krishna up: "Nothing doing. Without me, you cannot run a government," and argued through the night until he got his way.

All of this has made DKS a formidable leader, and also a rich one. His 2023 election affidavit declared assets of over Rs 1,413 crore, which makes him the richest among chief ministers, alongside 19 pending criminal cases (many of them protest-related, but there are also others concerning tax, alleged disproportionate assets and money-laundering enquiries). Not one has produced a conviction, and the most serious of them have eased: the income-tax complaints ended in his discharge, upheld by the Karnataka High Court in 2021. The 2018 money-laundering case was brought to a close by the Supreme Court in March 2024.

A few others persist. A 2020 CBI case alleging disproportionate assets of about Rs 75 crore, which the courts declined to quash, was withdrawn from the agency by the Siddaramaiah government and handed to the Lokayukta. A separate Enforcement Directorate matter remains under challenge, with the Delhi High Court extending him interim protection from coercive action as recently as April 2026.

## WHY SIDDA HAD TO QUIT

- **After the 2023 assembly poll win, D.K. Shivakumar was a strong CM contender, but Siddaramaiah got the chair. There was talk of a deal for a mid-term switch**
- **Karnataka Congress remains split between Sidda and DKS factions. The high command wanted to end the constant bickering**
- **The party brass was also looking to the future and the 2028 assembly polls; Sidda would be 80 by then. DKS, 14 years younger, was a safer bet**

## THE CASTE CRISIS

As party president for the past six years and the acknowledged architect of the 2023 campaign, Shivakumar is the Congress's structural mainstay in Karnataka. His base is the Vokkaligas, one of the state's two dominant caste blocs, the other being the Veerashaiva-Lingayats. This is a different coalition from the one that powered Siddaramaiah, a leader of the OBC Kuruba community whose strength lies in the grouping of minorities, backward classes and Dalits known by the Kannada acronym, AHINDA.

Reconciling these two power bases will be the first item on the new CM's agenda. The party must now rejig its Karnataka unit, appoint a successor as president, keep caste equations in balance and Siddaramaiah's bloc onside, all while staying alert to the challenge a BJP and JD(S) front could mount.

And then there is the caste survey, the challenge that arrived a day before the handover. On May 27, the Karnataka State Backward Classes Commission handed Siddaramaiah the report of the Social and Educational Survey 2025 at Vidhana Soudha. Its contents have not been made public, but its lineage is incendiary. The exercise had been ordered afresh after its predecessor's data, gathered in 2015, and thus deemed outdated, drew fierce opposition from the Vokkaligas and Lingayats, who rejected the 'undercounting', suspecting that it had been engineered to favour Siddaramaiah's Kurubas.

The caste census is also a signature campaign for Rahul Gandhi, who oversaw a similar exercise in Telangana. By leaving the 2025 report on the table, Siddaramaiah has bequeathed DKS a hot potato that pits his community's anxieties against his party's stated conviction. The Opposition will be watching for the slightest hint of a crack. So far, the Congress has had it easy, helped by the disarray in the rival camp, above all in the BJP, whose state unit has lumbered along for three years amid infighting.

## THE WAY FORWARD

The bigger threat to the new dispensation may be fatigue. The party has delivered on the five welfare guarantees it promised in 2023 and shown an appetite for reform in areas such as revenue and excise. What it now needs is fresh momentum. Shivakumar's window is narrow. Before the 2028 election year closes in, he must deliver on marquee projects, chief among them his ambition to transform the face of capital Bengaluru. There is also the neglected rural infrastructure and the long-pending demand to fill government vacancies. Besides that, there are the civic polls to fight: the Bengaluru city body by August, and the overdue gram panchayat elections. By Siddaramaiah's reckoning, the government has met 300 of the 550-odd manifesto promises, and left the state's finances within fiscal-responsibility norms. "No. 1 in the country in per capita income," he claimed on his way out, "No. 2 in GST collections."

The task before DKS is to carry the legacy forward. For a quarter of a century, he was the man the Congress sent for when a government was slipping away. Now, the government is his own, and the first crisis on his desk is one no resort retreat or midnight vigil can settle: a sheaf of caste numbers that sets his community against his party's conscience. The fixer has finally arrived at the one government he cannot be sent in to rescue, because it is his to run. ■